

Q My baby isn't her usual self, but there's nothing specific I can put my finger on. Should I call the doctor?

As a new parent, it can be hard to judge when your baby needs medical attention, or whether you are overreacting to a harmless sniffle.

Perhaps your baby hasn't been feeding well for a couple of days, or isn't quite as alert as usual. Since young babies often don't show many symptoms when they are sick, sometimes it can be hard to tell whether a baby is just a little under the weather or if there is something a bit more serious going on. For this reason, it's always best to listen to your voice of doubt and trust your instincts and get her checked over by your doctor. The chances are that there is nothing seriously wrong, but doctors are always happy to see young babies—and often prioritize them—and would rather that you erred on the side of caution. For example, a slight fever is usually nothing to worry about in an older child, but a fever is relatively unusual in a baby under three months old, and is sometimes the only sign of a more serious infection, so it's vital not to ignore it. Because a baby's immune system is still immature, they can be more susceptible to a secondary bacterial infection, and can deteriorate quite quickly. It's most likely that your doctor will be able to ease your mind but he or she will also reassure you that you did the right thing by making an appointment.



Keeping calm Try to stay calm since your baby will respond to how you are acting and will pick up on any stress.

Q Which symptoms always require medical attention?

There are certain symptoms and signs that should not be ignored and that should be dealt with quickly. Some signs (see bottom) need urgent attention.



SIGNS OF A SERIOUS ILLNESS

The following signs could signal that your baby has an illness and needs to see her pediatrician. Do not hesitate to call and make an appointment if you notice:

» **Behavioral changes** are often the first sign that something isn't right. If your baby is lethargic, drowsy, hard to rouse to be fed, or persistently irritable for no reason, this may indicate that she isn't feeling well.

» **Changes in crying patterns** or sounds, for example a lack of crying or unusual high-pitched cries.

» **Changes in feeding patterns** and feeding poorly, or if your baby refuses several feedings in a row.

» **Severe vomiting or diarrhea** that lasts for longer than 12 hours (see p.295), or that is streaked with blood or mucus should be assessed.

» **Signs of an eye infection**, or a discharge from the eyes.

» **Your baby isn't responding to sounds** or has a discharge from the ears.

» **A temperature of 100.4° F (38° C)** or more if she is under three months old; or of 102. 2° F (39° C) or more if she is under six months old.

» **A sunken or bulging fontanelle**, the soft spot on your baby's head should be checked. Usually, this should be firm to the touch and may dip in a little. When your baby cries, lies down, or is sick, the fontanelle can bulge, but it should return to normal when your baby is upright and calm.

» **An unexplained rash**, especially if it accompanies a fever or diarrhea.

» **Signs of dehydration** (see p.294).

» **Signs of constipation**, such as hard, small stools, with fewer bowel movements than usual.



CALL AN AMBULANCE

You should always call an ambulance if you notice that your baby is displaying any of these symptoms:

» **Stops breathing** or is struggling for breath.

» **A seizure**, even if she recovers.

» **Is unconscious** or unaware of what's going on.

» **One or more symptoms** of meningitis (see p.295).



GO TO THE EMERGENCY ROOM

Go immediately to the emergency room (ER) if you spot your baby showing any of the symptoms and issues listed below:

» **Has a fever and is persistently lethargic**, despite taking medication.

» **Has a cut that won't stop bleeding** or is gaping open.

» **Is having difficulty breathing**, including fast or panting breathing, or is very wheezy.

» **Has a serious fall or bump to the head.**

» **Has severe abdominal pain.**

» **Is turning blue.**